at the Regional Institute of Education, Bhopal (an NCERT constituent), Maneesha Pandey from the department of political science at Hindu College and two postgraduate schoolteachers. While there were two rounds of consultation for political science experts, the history experts were consulted only once.

Most historians, including the original authors of these textbooks, allege the NCERT's "arbitrary" changes were effected without consulting them. "There has been no attempt to consult members of the teams that had prepared the textbooks, which included historians and schoolteachers, apart from the members of the NCERT," a statement by 250 historians across the country read. Two authors of the political science textbooks for Classes 9 to 12, Yogendra Yadav, former senior fellow at the Centre for the Study of Developing Societies, and Suhas Palshikar, former professor with Pune University, smell a clear political motive behind these deletions. Former NCERT director Rajput agrees that the general norm is that the original authors be consulted before making changes to the text.

WHY BJP WANTS TO CHANGE TEXTBOOKS

This is not the first time that the BJP government has tried to revise history textbooks. 'Reform' of education has long been a part of the Sangh Parivar vision for "nation-building". They believe Indian education remains shackled to the imperial legacy of Thomas Macaulay and that India's post-Independence history-writing has been dominated by Leftist historians. Hence their attempts to find a way back to their version of Indian roots. Among their biggest complaints is that the Mughals find disproportionate space in history textbooks while regional heroes, particularly Hindu kings, have been relegated to the margins. They claim their objective is not to promote sectarianism, but to present a more "accurate" picture of Indian history. Between 1999 and 2004, BJP veteran Murli Manohar Joshi, the then Union minister for human resource development, initiated large-scale changes in school and higher education curriculum, with the declared intention of highlighting India's "glorious Hindu past". The NCF of 1988 was revised, and books written by Romila Thapar, R.S. Sharma, Satish Chandra and Bipan Chandra were specifically targeted for their purportedly 'anti-Hindu' prejudice.

Prime Minister Modi is now carrying forward that legacy. Both in 2014, when he first came to power, and in 2019, he has commanded a much larger mandate. The BJP now is aiming at more permanent education reform. This is the third revision of textbooks under the Modi government, the first having taken place in 2017 and the second in 2018-19. The prime minister also made it clear last December on which side of the divide he stands. Speaking at the 'Veer Bal Diwas' programme organised in Delhi by the Union ministry of culture, he said that concocted narratives were taught in the name of history to create a sense of inferiority among people. "On the one hand, there was the mighty Mughal Sultanate blinded by religious fanaticism, and on the other, there were our gurus gleaming in knowledge and living by the ancient principles of India," Modi said, in reference to the martyrdom of Guru Gobind Singh's sons.

Backing the PM's claim of such "distortions" are dedicated footsoldiers such as P.C. Bhandari, who filed an RTI petition in November 2020 seeking proof for the claim that Shah Jahan and Aurangzeb issued grants to repair temples demolished during wars—made on page number 234 of the Class 12 NCERT history textbook *Themes of Indian History III*. In response to the RTI, the NCERT stated that no proof existed to substantiate the claim. (Historians base the assertion on numerous royal firmans and land records.) Following this, in July 2021, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education sought submissions regarding "removing references to unhistorical facts and distortions about our national heroes from textbooks, ensuring equal or proportionate references to all periods of Indian history, and highlighting the role of great historic women heroes". Headed by BJP MP Vinay Sahasrabuddhe, the committee also met repre-

CUTS IN SOCIAL MOVEMENTS AND CASTE ISSUES

CLASS 12: POLITICAL SCIENCE

■ In ***Politics in India Since Independence***, a chapter on the rise of popular movements such as Chipko, the Dalit Panthers, agrarian struggles in the 1980s and the Narmada Bachao Andolan has been dropped. Another chapter titled 'Era of One-party Dominance' has also been removed.

CLASS 12: SOCIOLOGY

■ In ***Social Change and Development in India***, an exercise box that asks students to discuss the recent farmers' agitation has been removed.

CLASS 10: POLITICAL SCIENCE

■ Three chapters—'Democracy and Diversity', 'Challenges to democracy' and 'Popular struggles and movements'—have been removed from ***Democratic Politics-II***. They introduced students to the concept of social inequalities, talked about reforming democratic politics, and looked at indirect ways of influencing politics through pressure groups and movements